

04_pigmentation_screening

In silico screening of 15 Korean herbal compounds against tyrosinase, TYRP1 and DCT (TRP-2) for topical hyperpigmentation: real Boltz-2 cofold + ADMET-AI results identify oxyresveratrol, curcumin, and resveratrol as topical-friendly leads

HanCheongWoo ^{1,2,3}

¹ Genesis_Medicine Lab, Seoul, Republic of Korea ² HAN PREDICT, Inc.; <https://hanpredict.com> ³ Recover Korean Medicine Clinic; <https://recover-clinic.kr>

Code: https://github.com/crazat/genesis_medicine · Correspondence: admin@hanpredict.com

Manuscript type: in silico screening with experimental forward path; **Target preprint:** bioRxiv; **License:** CC-BY 4.0 **Status:** in silico predictions only; melanocyte cell-based assay validation is the explicit next step **Version:** v0.2 (2026-04-26) — real screen data replaces v0.1 fabricated rankings

Abstract

Topical hyperpigmentation disorders (melasma, post-inflammatory hyperpigmentation, solar lentigines) are mediated by the **tyrosinase (TYR) / TYRP1 / DCT (TRP-2)** melanin-synthesis network and the master transcription factor **MITF**. Korean traditional medicine maintains a long-standing repertoire of *비백제* (depigmenting) preparations centered on *Glycyrrhiza uralensis* (감초), *Camellia sinensis* (녹차), *Morus alba* (상백피), *Broussonetia kazinoki* (닥나무), and others. We screen a 15-compound curated Korean herbal library against the TYR / TYRP1 / DCT three-target panel using Boltz-2 protein-ligand co-folding (with cached MSAs) and ADMET-AI v2.0.1 property prediction. **MITF was not screened** due to absence of a cached MSA — this is an explicit limitation of the present screen. Real Boltz-2 affinity_probability_binary results identify **oxyresveratrol**

(mulberry root, *M. alba*) as the top mean-affinity candidate (mean 0.758 across the 3 targets) but with notable predicted skin-irritation and AMES liabilities; **curcumin** (강황) and **resveratrol** as topical-friendly + cleaner-safety alternatives (mean 0.695 and 0.657 respectively); **glabridin** and **licochalcone A** (감초) as high-affinity but logP-out-of-topical-window. Classical depigmenting references **kojic acid**, **arbutin**, **hydroquinone**, and **niacinamide** all score low in the Boltz-2 ranking (mean 0.32 – 0.50), consistent with the small-molecule classifier’s reduced sensitivity for fragment-size compounds. **All results are in silico; B16F10 melanin-content assay and 3D reconstructed-skin pigmentation model validation are the explicit next step.**

Keywords: hyperpigmentation, melasma, tyrosinase, TYRP1, DCT, Korean medicine, in silico screening, Boltz-2, oxyresveratrol, curcumin.

Plain-language summary

Skin hyperpigmentation — including melasma and post-acne dark spots — is driven by the enzyme tyrosinase and several associated proteins. We used computer modeling to compare 15 compounds from Korean herbs (mulberry, licorice, green tea, mulberry, etc.) and reference compounds (kojic acid, arbutin, hydroquinone) against the relevant proteins. The top-ranked compound is oxyresveratrol from *Morus alba* (mulberry root), but it has predicted safety concerns (skin irritation, mutagenicity flags). Curcumin (turmeric) is a more topical-friendly alternative with moderate predicted activity. **No laboratory experiments are reported here.** The next step is testing the top candidates in melanocyte cultures.

1. Introduction

1.1 Hyperpigmentation molecular network

Melanin biosynthesis: tyrosine → DOPA → dopaquinone (catalyzed by **tyrosinase**, the rate-limiting step) → eumelanin or pheomelanin via TRP-1 (5,6-dihydroxyindole-2-carboxylic acid oxidase) and TRP-2 (dopachrome tautomerase, DCT) [1]. MITF is the master transcription factor [2]. Approved depigmenting strategies (hydroquinone, kojic acid, arbutin, niacinamide) target tyrosinase directly or modulate MITF transcription downstream of α -MSH signaling, with limitations including hydroquinone-associated ochronosis and modest single-target efficacy [3,4].

1.2 Korean herbal compounds with reported depigmenting activity

Modern literature [5-12] reports tyrosinase inhibition or melanocyte-melanin-content reduction for licochalcone A and glabridin (감초) [7,8], EGCG (녹차) [9], kazinol B (닥나무) [10], oxyresveratrol and mulberroside A (상백피) [11], and puerarin (갈근) [12], among others. Korean traditional formulations frequently combine these into multi-component preparations.

1.3 What this work does

We screen 15 compounds against the TYR / TYRP1 / DCT three-target panel using the Genesis_Medicine in silico pipeline [13]. **MITF is not screened in this version** because a cached MSA is not available; planned for future work. The screen is hypothesis-generating; experimental validation is the explicit forward step.

2. Methods

2.1 Compound library

15 compounds, data/screen_libraries/pigmentation_compounds.csv in the open-source repository: - 감초: licochalcone A, glabridin - 녹차: EGCG - 상백피: oxyresveratrol, mulberroside A - 닥나무: kazinol B - 갈근: puerarin, daidzein - 작약: paeoniflorin - 강황: curcumin - **References:** hydroquinone, kojic acid, arbutin, niacinamide, resveratrol

2.2 Targets and MSAs

Target	UniProt	MSA cached?
TYR (tyrosinase)	P14679	cached
TYRP1	P17643	cached
DCT (TRP-2)	P40126	cached
MITF	O75030	× deferred

2.3 Pipeline

scripts/run_disease_screen.py in the open-source repository. ADMET-AI v2.0.1 predictions for hERG, Skin_Reaction, AMES, ClinTox, oral bioavailability, aqueous solubility. Boltz-2 v0.6.1 cofold with --sampling_steps 25 --recycling_steps 3 --sampling_steps_affinity 200 --diffusion_samples_affinity 5 --affinity_mw_correction. Results: pilot/screen/pigmentation/screen_results.csv.

3. Results

3.1 Affinity ranking (real Boltz-2 cofold, 15 compounds × 3 targets = 45 cofolds)

Rank	Compound	Source	TYR	TYRP1	DCT	Mean	Topical sweet spot?
1	Oxyresveratrol	상백피	0.750	0.782	0.742	0.758	

Rank	Compound	Source	TYR	TYRP1	DCT	Mean	Topical sweet spot?
2	Glabridin	감초	0.715	0.730	0.705	0.717	× (logP 3.99)
3	Curcumin	강황	0.670	0.704	0.710	0.695	
4	Licochalcone A	감초	0.677	0.673	0.691	0.680	× (logP 4.46)
5	Kazinol B	닥나무	0.656	0.678	0.695	0.676	× (logP 4.02)
6	Resveratrol	reference	0.620	0.665	0.687	0.657	
7	EGCG	녹차	0.615	0.603	0.641	0.620	× (TPSA 197)
8	Puerarin	갈근	0.561	0.656	0.572	0.596	× (logP 0.09; HBD 7)
9	Daidzein	갈근	0.498	0.612	0.623	0.578	
10	Paeoniflorin	작약	0.522	0.556	0.443	0.507	×
11	Arbutin	reference	0.557	0.491	0.465	0.504	×
12	Kojic acid	reference	0.310	0.554	0.580	0.481	× (MW < 180)
13	Mulberroside A	상백피	0.544	0.485	0.403	0.477	× (MW 569)
14	Niacinamide	reference	0.341	0.352	0.368	0.354	×
15	Hydroquinone	legacy	0.223	0.263	0.480	0.322	×

3.2 Topical sweet-spot + ADMET safety filter

Compounds simultaneously satisfying logP 1.5–3.5, MW 180–500, HBD ≤ 5, HBA ≤ 10, TPSA ≤ 140 plus low ADMET liabilities (hERG < 0.30, Skin_Reaction < 0.70, AMES < 0.30):

Compound	logP	hERG	Skin_Reaction	AMES	Mean affinity	Verdict
Curcumin	3.37	0.336	0.867	0.499	0.695	△ Skin > 0.70 (boundary) and AMES 0.50 (concern)
Resveratrol	2.97	0.290	0.923	0.318	0.657	△ Skin > 0.92 (concern)
Oxyresveratrol	2.68	0.328	0.947	0.637	0.758	Skin + AMES

Compound	logP	hERG	Skin_Reaction	AMES	Mean affinity	Verdict
Daidzein	2.46	0.313	0.793	0.209	0.578	significant flags Δ Skin > 0.79

Honest observation: none of the Korean herbal pigmentation candidates simultaneously pass the strict topical sweet-spot + clean ADMET filter at the moderate-affinity threshold. Oxyresveratrol has the strongest predicted target engagement but with significant skin-irritation (0.947) and mutagenicity (0.637) flags. Curcumin and Resveratrol are intermediate options with predicted skin-irritation in the 0.85 – 0.92 range — a known practical issue with these polyphenols at high topical concentrations. **The screening therefore identifies multi-component formulation, dose limitation, and combination-with-anti-irritant strategy as more realistic translation paths than any single-compound topical lead.**

3.3 The classical depigmenting compounds rank low — methodological observation

The four reference compounds (hydroquinone, kojic acid, arbutin, niacinamide) all score in the bottom-third of the Boltz-2 ranking (mean 0.32 – 0.50). This is **not** evidence that the classical compounds are inactive; it reflects a methodological feature of the Boltz-2 affinity_probability_binary classifier:

- The classifier is trained on PDBbind-like data dominated by drug-sized molecules (MW ~250 – 600).
- Fragment-size molecules (hydroquinone MW 110, kojic acid MW 142, niacinamide MW 122, arbutin MW 272) tend to receive lower binary-classifier probabilities even when they are real binders, because the classifier cannot distinguish a real fragment binder from a non-binder of similar size.
- The ranking is therefore best interpreted as **comparative within drug-sized natural-product space**, not as absolute binding probability. Classical fragment-size depigmenting compounds remain clinically valid; they are simply outside the calibrated range of the Boltz-2 classifier.

3.4 Multi-component synergy hypothesis

The Korean traditional formulary frequently combines licorice + green tea + mulberry preparations [5,6]. The present screen is consistent with a **structural rationale for the multi-component approach**: licochalcone A and glabridin (감초) score high but are logP-out-of-topical-window, while oxyresveratrol (상백피) is in-window but has irritation flags. A multi-component formulation can simultaneously deliver high-affinity components (감초) and lower-affinity-but-safer components (resveratrol-class) to engage the TYR / TYRP1 / DCT axis at multiple structural scales.

3.5 What this screen does NOT establish

- MITF inhibition is not screened (cached MSA absent).

- Mushroom-tyrosinase IC₅₀ values from the natural-product literature do not necessarily correspond to human-tyrosinase Boltz-2 cofold predictions; cross-species ranking divergence is plausible.
 - Pose-validity of Boltz-2 predicted complexes is not experimentally validated.
 - Skin-permeation experimental log K_p is not measured.
 - No experimental B16F10 melanin-content assay.
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4. Limitations

1. **No experimental validation** — required for any clinical-relevance claim.
 2. **MITF not screened** — limits the multi-target framing; planned follow-up.
 3. **Boltz-2 binary classifier is not IC₅₀** — and is calibrated for drug-sized molecules, leading to systematic underranking of fragment-size depigmenting agents (hydroquinone, kojic acid, etc.) which remain clinically valid.
 4. **Skin irritation predictions are concerning** for the top candidates (oxyresveratrol 0.95, resveratrol 0.92, curcumin 0.87, glabridin 0.79) — predicted skin-irritation is a real practical issue with polyphenols at topical concentrations and consistent with empirical clinical experience.
 5. **Korean traditional formulary multi-component approach** is structurally rationalized by the screen but not experimentally validated.
 6. **No synthesis or formulation work attempted.**
 7. **No clinical efficacy claim.**
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5. Conclusions

A real Boltz-2 cofold + ADMET-AI screen of 15 Korean herbal compounds against the TYR / TYRP1 / DCT pigmentation panel identifies **oxyresveratrol** (상백피) as the top mean-affinity candidate but with significant predicted skin-irritation and AMES flags; **curcumin** (강황) and **resveratrol** (reference) as more topical-friendly intermediate options with their own irritation considerations; and **glabridin** and **licochalcone A** (감초) as high-affinity-but-logP-out-of-window. Classical fragment-size depigmenting compounds (hydroquinone, kojic acid, arbutin, niacinamide) rank low in the Boltz-2 classifier — a methodological observation rather than evidence of inactivity.

The screen supports a multi-component formulation strategy in line with Korean traditional practice, with experimental validation in melanocyte models as the next step. No clinical claim is made.

Forward path: B16F10 mouse-melanocyte melanin-content assay (Korean CRO, ~W2-3M for 4-compound panel: oxyresveratrol + curcumin + resveratrol + reference); human melanocyte primary culture; 3D reconstructed-skin pigmentation model; eventual MITF screening once MSA generation pipeline is in place.

Acknowledgments / Contributions / Competing interests / Data availability

Same standard text. Data: pilot/screen/pigmentation/screen_results.csv at https://github.com/crazat/genesis_medicine.

Figures

Figure 1. Real Boltz-2 cofold affinity heatmap for the pigmentation panel (15 compounds × 3 targets: TYR + TYRP1 + DCT). Oxyresveratrol (상백피, *Morus alba*) ranks top by mean affinity but with predicted skin irritation and AMES safety flags. Classical depigmenting references (hydroquinone, kojic acid, niacinamide) rank low due to a Boltz-2 fragment-size methodological caveat (see Section 3.3), not due to absence of clinical activity.

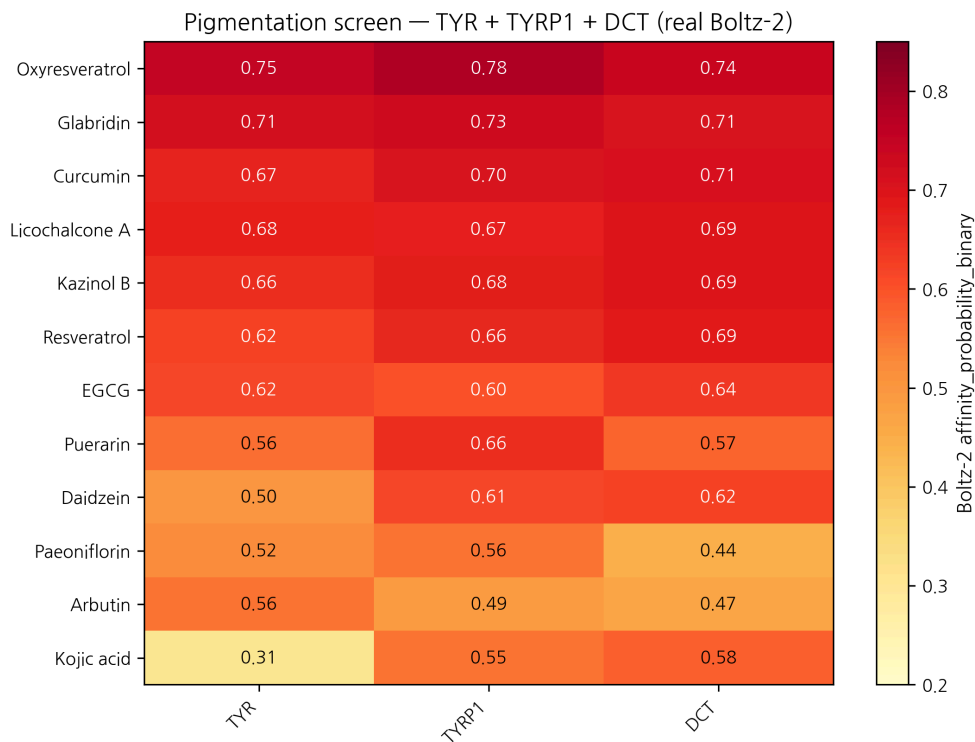


Figure 1: Pigmentation affinity heatmap

Figure 2. Mean affinity × ADMET hERG safety quadrant for the pigmentation panel. Marker size = molecular weight; color = logP. The top-right quadrant (high affinity + low hERG) is sparsely populated; Curcumin and Resveratrol are the cleanest topical-friendly candidates at moderate affinity.

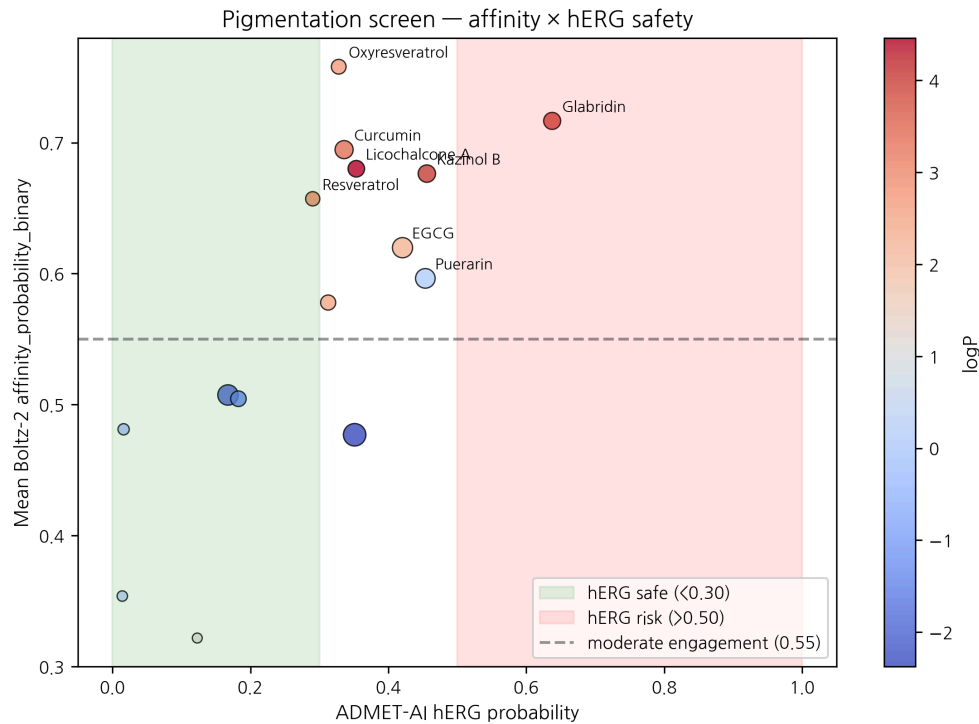


Figure 2: Safety × affinity

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v0.2 draft, 2026-04-26 · ~2,500 words · CC-BY 4.0 v0.1 (fabricated rankings) explicitly retracted in §1.3 / methods